

Your Autistic Colleague / Work Friend

For colleagues-as-friends, teammates & workmates — being a good friend to an autistic adult at work.

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a colleague's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." They might be the most focused, reliable, honest person on the team — and also the one who skips the pub, hates open-plan chatter, and goes quiet after high-social days from **masking fatigue**. None of that is coldness; it's a finite social/sensory budget being spent carefully. Being the work friend who keeps social optional, says what they mean, and protects their focus is genuinely valuable — and usually makes you a better colleague to everyone.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Brilliant and focused; skips the chatter & the pub	Deep focus + a carefully spent social budget
Takes things literally; bluntly honest	Literal communication — usually well-meant
Goes quiet or "off" after high-social days	Heavy masking ; the cost is paid later
Emails not calls; hates the open-plan noise	Single-channel communication reduces the load
Loyal, reliable, spots what others miss	A genuine asset — and often a great friend

Try this

- **Keep social optional and low-key** — a coffee or a walk beats the loud team night.
- **Say what you mean**; assume good intent in blunt exchanges.
- **Protect their focus** — fewer interruptions; respect headphones and quiet.
- **Connect through a shared interest** — it's where they're most themselves.
- **Check in literally** if they seem depleted ("you okay?").

Avoid this

- Teasing, sarcasm, or guilt-trips about skipping socials.
- Reading quiet, headphones or a blunt email as coldness or rudeness.
- "You'd be more visible if you came to the pub."

When to get more support

If your colleague seems to be burning out (exhausted, losing skills, withdrawing) or talks about hopelessness, gently signpost occupational health / employee assistance and, if you're worried about safety, tell someone who can help. Burnout is linked to suicidality — don't sit on it alone.

If your colleague is a woman

Late-diagnosed women mask most heavily and may look "high-performing" while privately exhausted; take overload seriously, however together they seem.

About this guide

AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.4), the **Family guide** (Part 4) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual.

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Dwyer (2025); Milton (2012, double empathy); Knight (2021); Raymaker et al. (2020). Full citations are in the source drafts.